

Closing time

Like at school, everything here follows the sound of soft, and familiar, alarms. You don't need a watch, just open your ears. At 8 a.m., the daily announcement lets everyone know what's happening and whether the boat will manage to cross the swell. At 12:30, the midday message brings news of the weather and the day's activities.

At 5 p.m., the first chime rings out, warning children that it's time to head back home. Then at 5:30, the final bell, *going home*, sounds. It gives a strangely formal air to the sunset, as if telling the night stars their break is over and it's time to get back to work.

And of course, it signals to the children that playtime is done. The island shifts. Space opens for the snakes, the centipedes, the wild boars, and the other creatures of the night.
